that Samant, who has represented Ratnagiri in the assembly since 2004, was being wooed by the BJP.

All in all, it's apparent to all stakeholders that things are in a flux. As a senior Congress leader notes, the MVA parties may be "in the fire" but the Sena and NCP too are "in the frying pan...the BJP will soon seek to grow at their expense". Shinde Sena spokesperson and MLC Manisha Kayande, though, denies any rift in the Mahayuti. "Every party has the right to expand its base. He (Shinde) is not upset and is working hard for the state," she says.



"They are taking me lightly...but I am a worker of Balasaheb and Dighe saheb (late Shiv Sena leaders). It'd be better if everyone understood this...."

EKNATH SHINDE
Deputy CM, Maharashtra

For now, it looks like Shinde will have to grin and bear it for the nature of the mandate is such. The BJP has 132 seats in the 288-member assembly, just 13 short of a majority, which doesn't leave much room for the allies to flex their muscles. Still, as Ajit Pawar commented at the Akhil Bharatiya Marathi Sahitya Sammelan on February 23, it's still a "mystery" what Shinde meant when he talked about not being taken lightly. The latter will be hoping some of that mystery holds if he and the Shinde Sena is to hold their own in the Mahayuti vortex. ■



MUJEEB FARUQUI

DEGRADED? An open forest in Madhya Pradesh

ENVIRONMENT

NOW, PRIVATE SECTOR FORESTS

By Rahul Noronha

Is Madhya Pradesh planning to hand out its forests to private investors? A draft document, 'Policy for Forest Restoration Using CSR, CER and Non-Governmental Funds', suggests precisely that. Placed for comments in the public domain by the state forest department ahead of the February 24-25 investor summit in Bhopal, it proposes to allow private investment for 'restoration of forest lands'—offering the investor the right to sell minor forest produce and earn carbon credits.

Madhya Pradesh has some 9.5 million hectares of land classified as forests, the biggest for any state. Of this, some 3.7 million ha has been classified as 'degraded'. The MP forest department estimates the cost of restoring these degraded forests at around Rs 5-8 lakh a hectare; the state pleads a paucity of funds to commit to this cause. Hence this policy, which has two parts: to get private investment in forestry, and to get corporates to support forest restoration through their Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Corporate Environment Responsibility (CER) budgets. Investors would have to take up a minimum forest area of 25 ha and a maximum of 1,000 ha, in consultation with the MP Forest Development Corporation (MPFDC). The latter would invite EOIs (expression of interests)

MADHYA PRADESH PROPOSES TO LET THE PRIVATE SECTOR INTO FORESTS, BUT ACTIVISTS WORRY IT WILL BLOCK LOCALS' ACCESS TO THEM